carded quickly, or popular music, where current hit songs rush up and down the sales charts.

The stock market is an excellent place to study mass behavior because it's unique as a place where specific, detailed and voluminous data exist. The main difficulty in assessing indicators of mood other than stock prices is the woeful lack of precise numerical data. Suppose we had trustworthy numbers on sporting-event attendance. On notes and note changes in popular melodies and the lyrical content of popular songs. On the story content in popular books. On hemline lengths, tie widths, heel heights, the prominence of various fashion and pop art colors. On the angularity vs. roundness of automobile styling. On the construction of various architectural styles. Then suppose all of this data were weighted according to volume of sales.

Why, in that case, we could read charts of the public mood in the same way we read charts of aggregate stock prices. The catch, of course, is that such data are not available. So, consider this article not as a systematically developed theory but, rather, the outline of an idea.

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Let's look more closely at the various facets of popular culture as indicators of the collective mood. We'll start with fashion. A correlation has long been observed, at least casually, between the trends of hemlines and stock prices. Skirt heights rose to miniskirt brevity in the 'Twenties and 'Sixties, peaking with stock prices both times. Floor-length fashions appeared in the 'Thirties and 'Seventies (the maxi), bottoming with stock prices. It is not unreasonable to hypothesize that a rise in both hemlines and stock prices